

and eggplants from all over. The souk is a unique phenomenon of the Middle East, found in almost every town of the region; some are virtually unchanged since medieval times.

Africa's Ever-Evolving Cuisine

The second largest landmass on Earth, Africa comprises over a billion people inhabiting environments that range from hot deserts and snow-capped mountains to tropical forests and coastal wetlands. The continent's diversity of both peoples and geography is reflected in the contrast of its cuisines.

In East Africa, cattle are kept as a form of currency and wealth, so beef is generally reserved for special occasions; lamb, goat, poultry, and game are all eaten too. Arabs who settled the coastal areas of East Africa over a millennium ago introduced rice and spices such as cinnamon and cloves, together with golden saffron from Persia. Later, Indian settlers introduced their own cuisines, including spices and curry dishes as well as legumes such as lentils, pickled vegetables, and breads such as chapatis. European colonization saw the introduction of citrus fruit and yet more spices

from their Asian colonies; chili peppers, peanuts, peppers, corn, and tomatoes from the New World; and tropical fruits from Brazil. Almost the only country in Africa to escape colonization – bar a brief, fiercely resisted seven-year period – was Ethiopia, which to this day retains much of its indigenous culture and cuisine, including its distinctive sourdough bread, *injera*.

North Africa, culturally part of the Middle East, shares that region's culinary traditions and influences, as well as boasting its own, particularly in regions close to the Atlantic and Mediterranean. South Africa's cooking is sometimes described as a “rainbow cuisine” because of the many influences that have shaped it.

The indigenous Bantu-speaking people lived on wind-dried meat and wild game roasted over fires – traditions still seen today in the form of biltong and the South African love of braai, or barbecues. Other influences included the Dutch and British colonizers and Asian immigrants, who introduced legumes, soups, and curries. The resulting culinary synthesis of Asian and Dutch influence can be seen in dishes such as *bobotie*.

West African cuisine is best known for its starchy staples made from the locally grown yams, cassava, cocoyams, corn, and plantain that accompany spicy stews and soups. Outside Muslim Africa, alcoholic drinks are widely brewed, from the wines of Tunisia and South Africa and the honey wine – *tej* – of Ethiopia to the widely consumed palm wine and millet beer. The Middle East and Africa are brimming with exciting tastes and sights.

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Left Seafood vendor in Forodhani Gardens, by the beach in Zanzibar, Tanzania
Below Spices for sale at the crowded Bzouriyah market in Old Damascus, Syria

